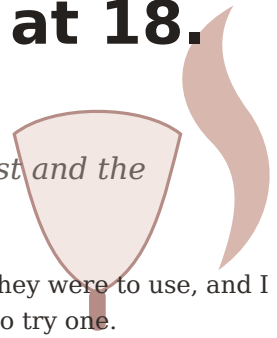

I Heard About Menstrual Cups at 18. So Why Didn't I Try One?

What one personal hesitation reveals about consumer adoption, trust and the difficulty of changing menstrual habits in India



I first heard about menstrual cups when I was 18. A few friends told me how easy they were to use, and I was curious. Yet, despite knowing about the product, I still could not bring myself to try one.

My first thought was: Will it be painful? The product looked intimidating. I did not know how insertion worked, whether it would hurt, or whether I would be able to use it correctly.

There was another barrier. Even if I decided to try one, I was unsure whether I could convince my mother. She was not even aware that such a product existed and I was not sure of her acceptance with the usage of internal menstrual products.

So instead of buying one, I started researching it.

That experience led to a broader question: if menstrual cups are repeatedly described as convenient, reusable and sustainable, why have they not become a mainstream menstrual product?

The more I explored the category, the clearer the problem became. This was not simply a question of whether the product worked. It was a question of adoption.

01 — The Product Exists. The Adoption Gap Does Too

Menstrual cups have been available in India for years, yet they remain a small part of the menstrual-care landscape. Findings from India's Fifth National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), show that among women aged 15–24 reported menstrual-product usage includes:

- 64.4% using sanitary pads
- 49.6% using cloth
- 15% using homemade napkins
- Only 0.3% using menstrual cups

The numbers point to an important consumer question: why does awareness of a product not automatically translate into adoption?

The barriers are unlikely to exist at a single point. They can emerge throughout the adoption journey—from discovering the product to considering it, trying it for the first time and eventually incorporating it into a routine.

02 — Awareness Is Not Adoption

Awareness alone does not appear to be the primary constraint.

In one Karnataka study, nearly 82% of participants had good awareness of menstrual cups, while only 2.6% had actually used one.

Once a consumer knows the product exists, the questions become more personal and practical:

- Is it safe?
- Will it hurt?
- How exactly do I use it?
- What if it gets stuck?
- Is insertion uncomfortable?
- Is it hygienic?
- Will I be able to use it correctly?

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- What will my family think?
 - Who can I ask if something goes wrong?

At this stage, the product is no longer competing only against another menstrual product.

It is competing against uncertainty.

03 — The Incumbent Isn't Just a Product. It's a Habit.

For many women, menstrual care is not a decision they consciously reconsider every month.

The existing product is already familiar.

You know how to use it. You know where to buy it. You know what to expect. Your mother may have used it. Your friends may use it. There is no significant learning curve.

A menstrual cup introduces a different experience. It asks the consumer to learn something new in a highly personal context.

That creates friction.

The fundamental consumer problem is therefore broader than product preference. The cup is not simply asking consumers to switch products. It is asking them to change a behaviour.

04 — The First-Use Problem

The first experience matters disproportionately.

For someone who has never used an internal menstrual product, the first attempt can involve uncertainty at every step:

- How should it be folded?
- How should it be inserted?
- How far should it go?
- Is it positioned correctly?
- How should it be removed?

Every additional point of uncertainty creates another opportunity for the consumer to abandon the product.

Yet the experience can change with familiarity.

This suggests an adoption journey:

Before use → uncertainty

First use → friction

Regular use → familiarity

Familiarity → perceived convenience

For a category with a learning curve, the challenge is therefore not only communicating the end-state benefit. It is helping consumers navigate the experience of trying something unfamiliar.

05 — The Consumer Is Evaluating More Than Functionality

A traditional product comparison might focus on functional trade-offs:

Product	Familiarity / Benefits	Key Concerns
Pads	Familiar and easy to use	Potential concerns around discomfort, waste and allergies
Tampons	Convenient and discreet	Concerns around TSS, dryness and recurring cost

Product	Familiarity / Benefits	Key Concerns
Menstrual cups	Reusable and high capacity	Insertion and the learning curve

But consumers do not evaluate intimate products on functionality alone.

They also evaluate perceived risk.

A consumer may think:

“It might be safe, but I don’t know how to use it.”

That uncertainty can be enough to stop the purchase altogether.

06 — My Mother Was Part of the Adoption Problem

Looking back, my hesitation was not purely personal. It was also social.

I was not only asking myself, “Can I use this?”

I was also asking:

“Can I introduce this product into my household?”

My mother did not know what a menstrual cup was. I was not sure if she would accept it's usage because of the taboo around this topic.

This highlighted an important aspect of the category: the person who discovers a product is not necessarily the only person involved in its adoption.

In some households, menstrual products are not completely individual purchasing decisions.

07 — The Household Is Part of the Market

Parents can influence what younger women feel comfortable trying.

Doctors influence perceptions of safety. Friends influence discovery. Social media influences curiosity. Communities influence normalisation.

This creates an important distinction between the target user and the decision influencer.

A young woman may ultimately use the product, but in semi-urban households, parental trust can materially influence whether she feels comfortable experimenting with an unfamiliar menstrual product.

That means the go-to-market strategy cannot stop at reaching young women through digital platforms.

It also has to address the household-level trust surrounding the user.

08 — A Different GTM Opportunity: Reach the User and the Mother

In semi-urban markets, menstrual-product adoption may be influenced not only by awareness but also by household-level trust, particularly from parents.

Traditional digital marketing may therefore have limited effectiveness in segments where the mother or family remains an important decision influencer.

A more distinctive approach is to take menstrual-health education into mainstream entertainment and regional content that mothers already consume.

Mother-Daughter Storytelling

Instead of presenting menstrual cups as a product advertisement, mainstream television serials and regional content could introduce the topic through familiar household situations.

A mother-daughter conversation about menstrual products, for example, can make an unfamiliar product part of an ordinary family discussion.

Doctor-Led Guidance Within Entertainment

Doctor or healthcare-professional characters can address questions around safety, use and hygiene within the storyline.

This can provide credibility without forcing the audience into a conventional educational campaign.

Regional-Language Normalisation

Regional content can carry menstrual-health narratives beyond English-speaking digital communities.

The objective is not to tell the audience to buy immediately. It is to make the subject less unfamiliar and the conversation easier to have at home.

Why Mothers Matter

The mother can act as a trust bridge between awareness and trial.

If the person who influences household decisions understands the product, the young consumer may face less resistance when she considers trying it.

This reframes the audience strategy from:

“Young women as customers”

to:

“Young women as users + mothers as important trust and decision influencers.”

09 — Trust Becomes Part of the Product

For a product with a learning curve, education is not simply marketing.

It becomes part of the product experience.

A first-time consumer may need:

- Demonstrations
- Credible explanations
- Reassurance around safety
- Clear instructions
- Answers to uncomfortable questions
- Testimonials from relatable users
- Access to trusted professionals
- Someone to ask when the first attempt does not go perfectly

The onboarding experience can therefore matter almost as much as the physical product itself.

10 — The Social Layer of Adoption

There is another barrier that does not appear on a product specification sheet: stigma.

Menstruation itself remains a sensitive topic. Introducing a product that requires consumers to think and talk about insertion can make the psychological barrier even stronger.

This is why simply saying “menstrual cups are sustainable” may not be enough.

Sustainability is a long-term benefit. The immediate question for a first-time consumer may be:

“But will I be comfortable using this on my next period?”

The immediate problem has to be addressed before the long-term benefit can influence behaviour.

11 — Sustainability Has to Compete With Immediate Friction

The environmental argument for reusable menstrual products is compelling.

But consumers rarely adopt products solely because they are better for the environment. Adoption happens when the personal value proposition is strong enough.

For a menstrual cup, that value proposition can combine:

- Comfort
- Convenience
- Confidence
- Safety
- Economics
- Sustainability

If the first experience is intimidating, sustainability may not be enough to overcome the friction.

This creates a broader go-to-market lesson:

A product's strongest macro benefit does not necessarily solve the consumer's most immediate problem.

12 — The Adoption Problem May Be Bigger Than the Product Problem

When a category has low penetration, the instinct is often to improve the product:

Make it more comfortable.

Make it easier to insert.

Make it better designed.

But the bottleneck can exist around the product:

- Education
- Trust
- First experience
- Support
- Habit formation

A technically strong product can still struggle against an alternative that is familiar if the switching cost feels too high.

The challenge is therefore not necessarily to create a fundamentally different product. It may be to make the transition into the product easier.

13 — What Should a Company Actually Solve?

If menstrual cups are viewed as a consumer business, the question is not simply:

“How do we convince more women to use menstrual cups?”

A more useful framing is:

“How do we reduce the psychological and practical friction between curiosity and confident first use?”

Product

Can first-time use be made less intimidating?

Education

Can instructions answer the questions a first-time user may be afraid to ask?

Trust

Can credible people—doctors, educators or experienced users—reduce perceived risk?

Community

Can women hear from people who have actually gone through the transition?

Family

Can the product be normalised within households rather than positioned as a secret individual decision?

Content

Can education show the actual experience instead of simply listing benefits?

14 — The GTM Is Part of the Product

For a category with a behavioural barrier, distribution cannot be separated completely from education.

- Digital-first channels can create discovery.
- Influencers can demonstrate normalised usage.
- Doctors and medical professionals can provide credibility.
- Community-based education can address questions consumers may hesitate to search publicly.
- Mother-daughter conversations can reduce household resistance.
- Regional entertainment content can reach consumers beyond English-speaking digital communities.

The objective is not simply:

“Buy a menstrual cup.”

It is a broader journey:

Understand → Trust → Try → Learn → Continue using

15 — The Bigger Consumer Insight

My initial assumption was simple.

Maybe menstrual cups were not mainstream because people did not know enough about them.

But the research made me reconsider that assumption.

If awareness can coexist with low usage, awareness alone is not sufficient.

And if first-time users can experience difficulty while regular users later report convenience, the category has to think about the transition into use, not only the end-state benefit.

Consumers are being asked to cross a behavioural gap: from something familiar to something unfamiliar.

The wider that gap feels, the more support the consumer needs.

16 — What This Means for the Category

The menstrual cup category does not necessarily need consumers to believe that pads are bad.

It needs consumers to believe that trying something new is manageable.

That creates an opportunity to move from product education to adoption education.

Not only:

“Here are the benefits of a menstrual cup.”

But:

“Here is what happens when you try one for the first time. Here is what may feel unfamiliar. Here is how you navigate it. And here is how familiarity can change the experience.”

Final Thought

When I first heard about menstrual cups at 18, I thought my problem was simply fear: fear of pain, insertion, doing something wrong, or explaining it at home.

But perhaps the more useful consumer insight is that unfamiliarity creates a need for support.

The product may not be fighting another product alone. It may be fighting habit, uncertainty, social conditioning and a lack of trusted information.

That is what makes menstrual cups an interesting consumer case.

Sometimes the question is not:

“Why isn’t the consumer buying this?”

It is:

“What has to become true before the consumer feels comfortable trying it?”